

Darwinbox vs Keka vs Zoho People

Which HR platform wins
at which company size?

Positioning, pricing, features, customer sentiment and strategy for three HR platforms widely shortlisted in India. Vendor claims, reseller content and independent data are kept apart, and gaps are stated.

Headcount and existing software decide the winner, not feature lists

Zoho People: small teams

Cheapest list price (₹48 to 192 per user per month) and native links to Zoho Books, CRM and Analytics. Payroll is a separate product, and reviewers call the interface complex.

Keka: payroll-first mid-market

Guided payroll setup, self-serve rollout in weeks and a cleaner interface. Third-party comparisons praise its statutory compliance for 50 to 500 employees.

Darwinbox: large enterprises

Deepest talent, analytics and workflow depth. Quote-based pricing, implementation of months and a roughly ₹2 to 8 lakh setup, so it is over-sized below about 300 employees.

Strongest evidence gap: no independent data on churn or realised prices. The deck separates what vendors say from what third parties report.

What was compared and how far the sources can be trusted

Compared

Positioning, scale, financials, pricing, feature coverage, rollout effort, customer ratings and strategic direction. Indian buyers with 50 to 5,000 employees. India payroll compliance (PF, ESI, professional tax, TDS) is the baseline.

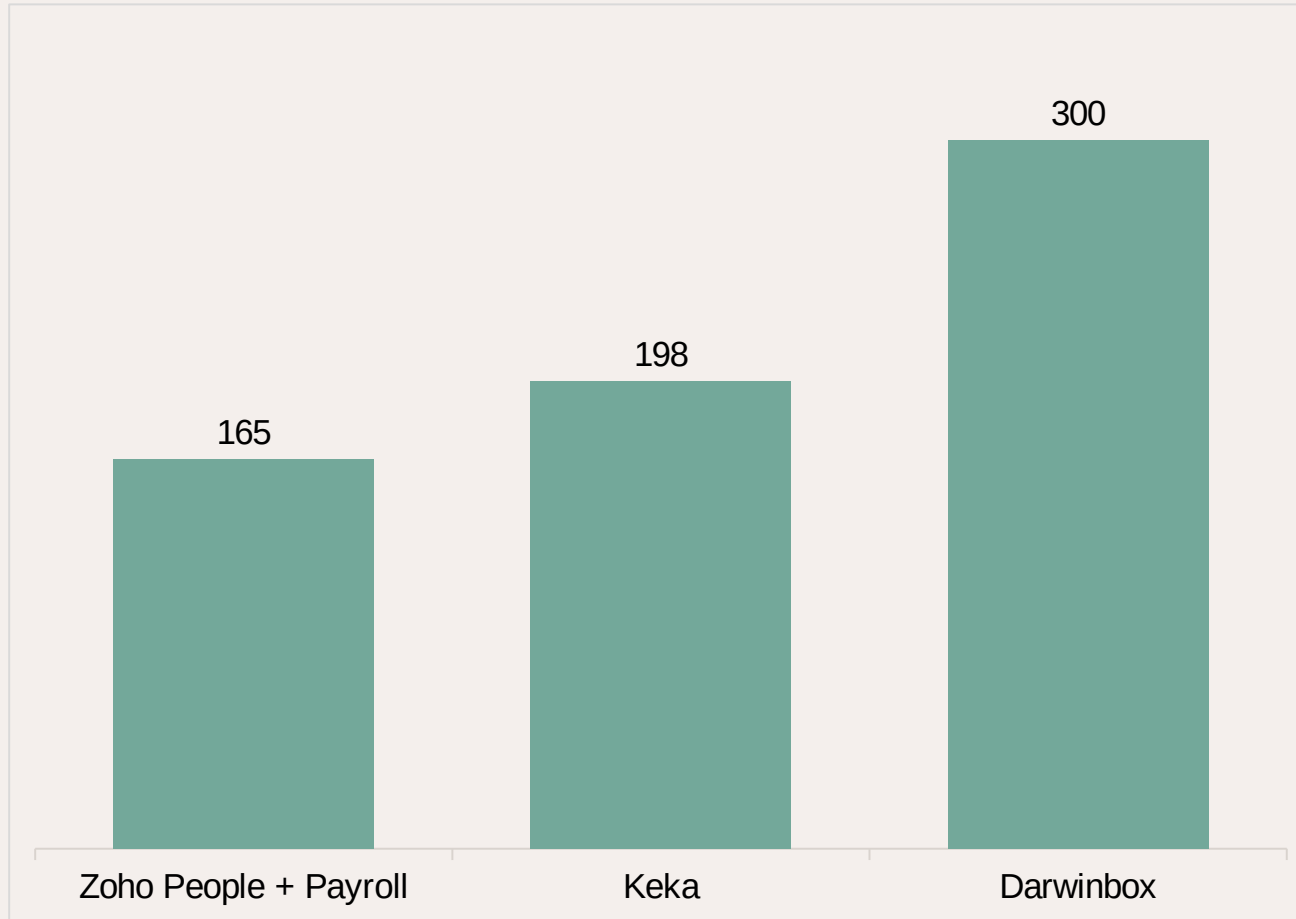
Source types

Company filings reported by Entrackr and Inc42. Vendor pages for scale claims (marked "vendor claim"). Pricing pages and reseller summaries for prices. Review-site scores quoted from comparison pages, not pulled from the sites.

Three different businesses sit behind similar-looking products

	Darwinbox	Keka	Zoho People
Owner	Hyderabad, venture-funded	Hyderabad, venture-funded	Part of Zoho Corporation, Chennai, bootstrapped
Scale (vendor claim)	900+ enterprises, 2.5 million+ employees	12,500+ companies, 2.5 million+ employees, 150+ countries	Not disclosed by product
FY25 revenue	₹534 crore, up 50%; overseas 63% of new sales	₹134 crore, up 54%; net loss ₹72 crore	Zoho group ₹12,313 crore; People not split out
Funding	USD 140 million round, Mar 2025	USD 57 million Series A, Nov 2022	None; group profit ₹3,191 crore
Core buyer	1,000+ employees, multi-country	50 to 2,000 employees	Small to mid firms, Zoho users

At 200 employees Zoho is cheapest and Darwinbox costs 1.5 to 1.8 times as much



Bands behind the bars

Zoho People + Payroll: ₹150 to 180.

Keka: ₹175 to 220.

Darwinbox: ₹250 to 350.

Implementation: Zoho ₹0.5 to 1.5 lakh via partner, Keka ₹0 to 0.5 lakh self-serve, Darwinbox ₹2 to 8 lakh.

Darwinbox does not publish prices. Other sources put its band at ₹180 to 600, so the bar is a mid case.

The list-price logic differs as much as the level

	Darwinbox	Keka	Zoho People
Model	Quote per employee per month, 1 to 3 year contracts, modules bundled	Flat monthly base for first 100 employees, then per employee	Per user per month, public list, 5-user minimum
Indicative price	₹200 to 600 per employee per month (third-party)	Base ₹7,000 to 16,000 a month plus ₹90 to 150 per extra employee	₹48 to 192 per user per month, annual billing
What it means	Price falls with headcount; negotiation matters	Cheapest near 100 employees, rising beyond	Easy to compare, but payroll is a separate bill

Darwinbox leads on depth, Keka on payroll polish, Zoho on its ecosystem

Capability	Darwinbox	Keka	Zoho People
Performance management	Advanced	Yes	Yes
Recruitment (ATS)	Full ATS	Basic	Via Zoho Recruit
Learning management	Yes	Basic	Yes (Zoho Learn)
Analytics and reporting	Advanced	Built-in	Via Zoho Analytics
Mobile app	Excellent	Good	Good
Ecosystem integration	API only	API only	Native with Zoho apps
Rollout time	3 to 6 months	4 to 6 weeks self-serve	4 to 12 weeks, faster with partner

Winner by company size

Segment	Likely winner	Why
Under 100 employees	Zoho People	Lowest cost, free tier for tiny teams, simple core HR. Weak if payroll must be one product
100 to 500, payroll-led	Keka	Guided payroll and compliance, self-serve rollout, cleaner UI. Reviewers flag setup effort and add-on cost
100 to 500, on Zoho One	Zoho People	Bundle pricing and native finance and CRM links outweigh Keka's polish
1,000+ or multi-country	Darwinbox	Depth in talent, analytics and entity management. Gartner lists it as a Challenger in its 2026 HCM quadrant (Darwinbox page)

Review scores are close, but review volume is not

4.5

Keka on G2, about 1,800 reviews (as quoted)

4.4

Zoho People on G2, about 376 reviews (as quoted)

n/a

Darwinbox: no comparable G2 figure gathered;
shown on Gartner Peer Insights

Zoho People themes: feature-rich but complex for new users; confusing pricing for one G2 reviewer.

Keka themes: clean interface; steeper initial setup; Keka also has far more reviews, which suggests wider SMB adoption.

Darwinbox themes: smooth single-platform HR; one verified reviewer flags inconsistent syncs with other systems.

Each vendor is pulling in a different direction

Darwinbox: go global

Overseas revenue grew 83% in FY25 and was 63% of new sales. USD 140 million raised to compete with Deel and Rippling in the US. Risk: India mid-market gets less attention.

Keka: add the US

Keka's own site now sells US multi-state payroll and benefits (vendor claim). FY25 revenue of ₹134 crore against a ₹72 crore loss shows the cost of scaling. Risk: thin margin for error.

Zoho: bundle and defend

HR is one app in a group earning ₹12,313 crore. Can price below pure plays and cross-sell Books, CRM and Recruit. Risk: HR stays a side product.

White space: analytics-led HR for 100 to 500 employee firms

Darwinbox analytics need an enterprise budget. Keka's are built-in but lighter. Zoho routes analytics through a separate product. Mid-sized Indian firms with a small HR team have no clear leader on workforce analytics.

A buyer in this band should shortlist by stack first (Zoho users go Zoho), then by payroll complexity (multi-state or multi-entity points to Darwinbox), and use Keka as the default for the rest.

A vendor aiming at this gap would need analytics inside the plan, not as an add-on, at a price near Keka's price band of ₹175 to 220 per user per month.

What would turn this desk view into a buying or strategy recommendation

Gap	Why it matters	How to close it
Realised prices unknown	List prices and bands differ by source	Interview 8 to 10 buyers per vendor
Features from reseller view	Not a hands-on test	Run trials of each with one sample payroll
Review scores quoted second-hand	Dates and counts may be stale	Pull G2 and Gartner Peer Insights directly
No churn or retention data	Cannot rank customer loyalty	Ask 20 HR leaders who switched and why
Zoho People revenue unknown	Cannot size it against Keka	Estimate from Zoho seats and list price

Sources

Entrackr, 17 Oct 2025: Darwinbox FY25 revenue ₹533.9 crore; overseas sales

Inc42 DataLabs: Keka HR FY25 revenue ₹133.9 crore, net loss ₹71.8 crore

Economic Times, 8 Apr 2026: Zoho Corporation FY25 revenue ₹12,313 crore, profit ₹3,191 crore

TechCrunch, 5 Mar 2025: Darwinbox raises USD 140 million. Keka press, 8 Nov 2022: USD 57 million Series A

Darwinbox pages: explore.darwinbox.com (900+ enterprises; Gartner 2026 Challenger) are vendor claims

Keka pages: keka.com/pricing (12,500+ companies) and keka.com/us/llm-info are vendor claims

Aaxonix, 27 Jun 2026: India HRMS comparison, pricing and feature tables (Zoho implementation consultancy)

workclave.com Zoho and Keka pricing explainers; hrone.cloud Darwinbox and Keka pricing and comparison posts

hrsoftware.in Zoho People vs Keka (G2 scores as quoted); itforsme.in Darwinbox pricing; Zendikt HRIS guide, 8 May 2026